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Childcare Software Evaluation Scorecard

Scoring framework to compare childcare admin software on attendance, billing, subsidy, communication, compliance, scheduling, pricing, and mobile.

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Scoring framework to compare childcare admin software on attendance, billing, subsidy, communication, compliance, scheduling, pricing, and mobile.

- ☐ Confirm attendance dates match room records.
- ☐ Mark ratio notes that support licensing review.
- ☐ Attach subsidy claim evidence before filing.
- ☐ Keep guardian and pickup updates with the child record.

How to Use This Scorecard

Rate each software platform you are evaluating on a 1-5 scale across eight categories. Weight the categories based on what matters most to your program.

Scoring scale:

- **5** = Fully meets our needs, no workarounds required
- **4** = Meets most needs, minor gaps that we can live with
- **3** = Adequate, but requires manual workarounds for some tasks
- **2** = Significant gaps, would need to supplement with another tool
- **1** = Does not support this function or does it so poorly it is unusable

Suggested category weights (adjust for your program):

Category	Weight (%)	Why It Matters
Attendance tracking	15%	Your licensing compliance depends on accurate attendance records
Billing and invoicing	20%	Billing errors and late follow-ups directly hit your revenue
Subsidy management	15%	If you accept subsidies, this is non-negotiable
Parent communication	15%	Daily reports and messaging reduce phone interruptions
Licensing compliance	10%	Audit-ready reporting saves you hours during inspections
Staff scheduling	10%	Ratio tracking and schedule management prevent violations
Pricing model	10%	The tool needs to fit your budget, not the other way around
Mobile app quality	5%	Staff and parents use phones more than desktops

If you do not accept subsidies, move that 15% weight to billing and attendance. If you are a single-room in-home provider, staff scheduling might drop to 5%. The weights should reflect your actual daily operations, not a generic best practice.

Attendance Tracking

This is the feature your licensing inspector cares about most. The right software eliminates paper sign-in sheets and gives you an audit trail.

Score each platform on:

- **Digital check-in/check-out:** can parents sign children in and out from their phone, or does it require a tablet or kiosk at the door?
- **Timestamp accuracy:** does the system record exact arrival and departure times, or just mark “present”?
- **Absent/late notifications:** does the system alert you when an expected child has not arrived by a set time?
- **Historical reporting:** can you pull attendance records by child, by date range, or by classroom for licensing audits?
- **Multi-room tracking:** if you run multiple classrooms, does attendance track which room each child is in throughout the day?
- **Offline capability:** if your internet goes down, does check-in still work, or are you back to paper?

Red flags:

- No way to export attendance data (you are locked into their system for licensing reports)
- Check-in requires a specific device that you must purchase from the vendor
- No distinction between “absent” and “not enrolled today” for part-time children

Platform	Digital Check-In	Timestamps	Absent Alerts	Historical Reports	Multi-Room	Offline	Score (1-5)
Platform A							
Platform B							
Platform C							

Billing and Invoicing

Billing is where most childcare providers lose money. Not because families do not pay, but because invoices go out late, discounts are applied inconsistently, or overdue balances are not followed up.

Score each platform on:

- **Auto-generated invoices:** does the system create invoices automatically based on the child's enrollment schedule and rate?
- **Multiple rate support:** can you set different rates for different age groups, full-time vs. part-time, and sibling discounts?
- **Late fee automation:** does the system automatically apply your late payment fee after the due date, or do you have to calculate and add it manually?
- **Payment processing:** can parents pay directly through the platform (ACH, card, or bank transfer)? What is the processing fee?
- **Payment tracking:** does the system show you at a glance who has paid, who is overdue, and by how much?
- **Receipt and statement generation:** can parents access their payment history and download receipts for tax purposes (especially the year-end childcare expense statement)?
- **Deposit and registration fee handling:** can you invoice one-time fees separately from recurring tuition?

Red flags:

- No automated invoicing (you manually create each invoice from scratch)
- No built-in payment processing (families must Venmo you separately and you reconcile manually)
- Cannot handle variable schedules (e.g., a child enrolled Mon/Wed/Fri at one rate and adding a Thursday at a different rate)

Platform	Auto Invoicing	Multiple Rates	Late Fee Automation	Payment Processing	Payment Tracking	Tax Receipts	Score (1-5)
Platform A							
Platform B							

Subsidy Management

If your program accepts government childcare subsidies (CCDF, state-specific programs), this category is critical. Subsidy billing is a different workflow from private-pay billing, and not all software handles it.

Score each platform on:

- **Subsidy tracking per child:** can you record which children receive subsidies, the agency, authorization dates, and approved hours?
- **Co-pay calculation:** does the system automatically calculate the family's co-pay portion versus the subsidy portion?
- **Attendance-to-claim alignment:** does the system match attendance records to subsidy-authorized hours so your claims are accurate?
- **Agency reporting formats:** can the system generate reports in the format your subsidy agency requires, or do you have to re-enter data into the agency's portal?
- **Authorization expiration alerts:** does the system warn you when a child's subsidy authorization is approaching its end date?
- **Multiple subsidy sources:** if a child receives subsidies from more than one program, can the system handle split funding?

Red flags:

- The platform treats subsidies as a simple discount rather than a separate billing workflow
- No way to track authorization periods or get expiration reminders
- You still have to manually enter attendance into the agency's system because the software cannot export in the right format

If you do not accept subsidies, skip this category and redistribute the weight.

Parent Communication

Daily communication with families is part of the job. The right software makes it efficient instead of time-consuming.

Score each platform on:

- **Daily reports:** can staff create and send daily activity reports (meals, naps, diaper changes, milestones) from a phone during the day?
- **Photo and video sharing:** can staff share photos securely with only the child's authorized family members?
- **Two-way messaging:** can parents message you through the app, and can you respond when it is appropriate?
- **Broadcast announcements:** can you send a message to all families at once (closures, events, reminders)?
- **Translation support:** if you serve multilingual families, does the platform offer message translation?
- **Notification controls:** can parents choose how they receive notifications (push, email, SMS)?

Red flags:

- Photos are shared via a public feed where all parents see all children (privacy issue)
- No distinction between urgent and non-urgent messages
- Messaging only works on the desktop version, not the mobile app

Platform	Daily Reports	Photo Sharing	Two-Way Messaging	Broadcasts	Translation	Score (1-5)
Platform A						
Platform B						

Licensing Compliance Features

Software that helps you stay audit-ready saves you the scramble every time your licensor visits.

Score each platform on:

- **Ratio monitoring:** does the system track how many children are present per room and flag when you approach or exceed your ratio?
- **Staff qualification tracking:** can you store and track staff CPR certifications, background checks, and training hours with expiration alerts?
- **Incident reporting:** does the system provide a structured incident report form that captures the details your state requires?
- **Drill documentation:** can you log fire drills, tornado drills, and lockdown drills with dates and notes?
- **Health record storage:** can you store immunization records and allergy documentation per child?
- **Audit-ready exports:** can you generate a full compliance report that covers the key items a licensing inspector will ask for?

Red flags:

- No ratio tracking (you are back to counting heads and checking a printed chart)
- No document expiration alerts (a staff member's CPR cert lapses and you do not know until the inspection)
- Incident reports are free-text only with no required fields for date, time, children involved, and action taken

Staff Scheduling

For centers with multiple staff, scheduling affects both ratio compliance and labor cost.

Score each platform on:

- **Shift scheduling:** can you build and publish weekly schedules within the platform?
- **Ratio-aware scheduling:** does the system flag shifts where your scheduled staff count falls below the ratio requirement for enrolled children?
- **Availability and time-off requests:** can staff submit availability and PTO requests through the app?
- **Clock-in/clock-out:** does the system track actual hours worked for payroll purposes?
- **Substitute management:** can you maintain a substitute list and quickly assign subs to open shifts?
- **Labor cost tracking:** does the system show you your total labor cost per day or per child?

For in-home providers with no employees, this category may be less relevant. Reduce its weight or skip it.

Pricing Model

Childcare software pricing models range from flat monthly fees to per-child charges. The right model depends on your program size.

Score each platform on:

- **Pricing transparency:** is the pricing published on the website, or do you need a sales call to learn the cost?
- **Per-child vs. flat rate:** per-child pricing (e.g., \$3/child/month) works for small programs. Flat rates favor larger centers. Calculate your cost at your current enrollment.
- **Free tier availability:** some platforms offer a free version with limited features. Is the free version usable or just a bait-and-switch?
- **Contract requirements:** monthly vs. annual commitment? Cancellation terms?
- **Payment processing fees:** if the platform processes parent payments, what is the per-transaction fee? (Typically 1-3% plus a flat per-transaction charge)
- **Hidden costs:** setup fees, training fees, additional classroom charges, premium support?

Calculate your annual cost for each platform:

Platform	Monthly Fee	Annual Fee	Per-Child Add-On	Payment Processing Fees	Setup/Training	Total Year 1 Cost
Platform A						
Platform B						

Mobile App Quality

Staff and parents use phones for nearly everything. A clunky app creates frustration and reduces adoption.

Score each platform on:

- **Staff app:** can teachers complete daily reports, check in children, and send messages from their phone?
- **Parent app:** can parents view daily reports, make payments, and communicate from their phone?
- **App store ratings:** check the current rating on iOS App Store and Google Play. Below 3.5 stars is a warning sign.
- **Speed and reliability:** does the app load quickly, or does it lag and crash?
- **Push notifications:** do both staff and parents receive timely push notifications?
- **Offline functionality:** does the app work if your facility's internet goes down?

How to test this yourself:

- Download the app before you buy. Most platforms let you create a trial account.
- Send a few test messages and photos. How long does it take?
- Check the most recent app reviews (not the older ones). Recent negative reviews about bugs or outages are a better indicator than the overall star rating.

Final Scoring Summary

After rating each platform across all categories, calculate the weighted total:

Category	Weight	Platform A Score	Platform A Weighted	Platform B Score	Platform B Weighted	Platform C Score	Platform C Weighted
Attendance	15%						
Billing	20%						
Subsidy Mgmt	15%						
Parent Comms	15%						
Licensing	10%						
Staff Scheduling	10%						
Pricing	10%						
Mobile App	5%						
Total	100%		_____		_____		_____

The highest score wins, but check for dealbreakers. If a platform scores a 1 in any category that is critical for your program (like subsidy management if 40% of your families receive subsidies), that single score should disqualify it regardless of the total.

Request a trial or sandbox account from your top two scoring platforms. Use them for a full week of simulated operations before committing. Demos show you the best version of the software. A trial shows you the real one.

